

INTERVIEW **A.P.J. ABDUL KALAM**

“I DIDN'T GET ANY PAPERS ON CLEMENCY TO AFZAL GURU”

Two days before he relinquished office as the President of India, Dr A.P. J. Abdul Kalam spoke to Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA about his presidency years. Excerpts:

Q. The country has just elected its first woman President to take over from you. What is your feeling about this?

A. It is indeed good news.

Q. According to some media polls, much of the nation seemed keen to re-elect you as President. Why did you turn down the request of the NDA to be their nominee?

A. There were many requests in various forms from the public for my second term. Whichever political party or group met me, I told them consensus was essential for my taking part in the presidential election. I did not deviate from the principle of consensus.

Q. Why?

A. I didn't want any political process at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. In the absence of a consensus, there would have been political activity at the Rashtrapati Bhavan, which I wanted to avoid at all costs.

Q. Why did you subsequently indi-

cate to the UNPA leaders that you would reconsider if there was a certainty about you being re-elected? And then you announced that you would not accept a second term.

A. I told them the same point about the need for a consensus. They said they would persuade others and so I said okay. Then when they came back to me and said they could not do it, I said okay (I will not stand).

Q. When you took over as President, what did you want to achieve? And at the end of five years, do you feel you have been able to transform the presidency the way you wanted it to?

A. I was propagating the programme of transforming India into a developed nation by 2020. When I became President, I definitely marketed it to Parliament and 14 state governments. I am satisfied that this movement has begun in the length and breadth of the nation, and particularly that the youth are inspired to make the nation great. Above all, Rashtrapati Bhavan itself became people's Bhavan. Over half a million to a million people visited Rashtrapati Bhavan every year.

Q. When you were DRDO chief, you

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SIPRA DAS

